

Blocking Storyboard

Every move, entrance, exit and light change — the picture and the line it lands on. Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi

HOW TO USE IT

- **One card = one moment.** Read top to bottom, in order, act by act and part by part. The text beside each picture is the verbatim line from the script where the move happens — nothing added.
- **The picture is the stage from above.** The audience sits at the bottom edge (↓). Everyone on stage in that moment is placed as a labelled dot. The move is drawn from a **solid dot** (where the character starts), along a **dashed arrow**, to a **hollow ring** (where they end). A **burst** marks a sudden event — the veil, the revolver, the gunshot.
- **Doors are labelled on the frame** — the gaps in the wall. Entrances and exits run to and from them, and each tag names *which way*: *enters · door at back · USC, EXIT · unhurried, out of the office · SL, to the wings · SR, leaves toward the house · downstage*.
- **The light is named on every card** — the badge top-right, and the floor is tinted to match the cue. The set is drawn per act: the chair-circle (One), the two-level platform with shower column, piano and pegs (Two), the fountain with the Manager's table and its bare bulb (Three). □ is the Boy-chair, ◇ the Child-bundle.

ORIENTATION — WHICH WAY IS WHICH

The audience sits at the foot of every map (**downstage**, DS); the back wall is the top (**upstage**, US). Because the actors face the house, the actor's right — **stage-right (SR)** — is the *left* of the page, and **stage-left (SL)** is the right. So *USC* = upstage centre (the door at back), *SL* = the prompt side here (office, dressing rooms), *SR* = the opposite wing. Every entrance and exit names its direction.

THE LIGHT CUES

HALF-DARK	the bare work-light of an empty house, before the play
WORK LIGHT	full white rehearsal light
REHEARSAL	the light brought down for “Mixing It Up”
AMBER WASH	the tenuous light of the Six
DEEP RED	as they cross off to the office
SHOWER	the tight overhead column on one figure
CURTAIN ↓ / ↑	the curtain falls / rises
FOUNTAIN + BULB	only the fountain glow and the bare bulb
BLACKOUT	full dark — the gunshot
LIGHTS SNAP UP	the snap back after the shot

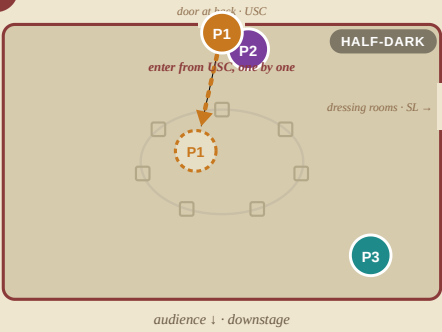
WHO IS WHO

F Father	M Mother	SD Step-Daughter	S Son	MG Manager	P1 Player 1
P2 Player 2	P3 Player 3	MP Madame Pace	BOY Boy-chair	CH Child-bundle	

Act One — The Family

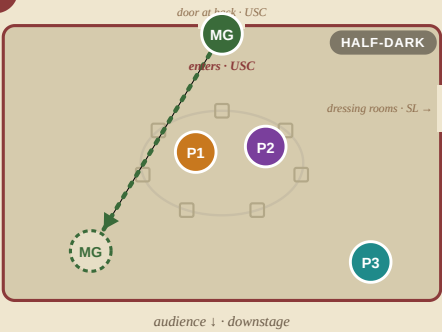
PART I — THE REHEARSAL

1



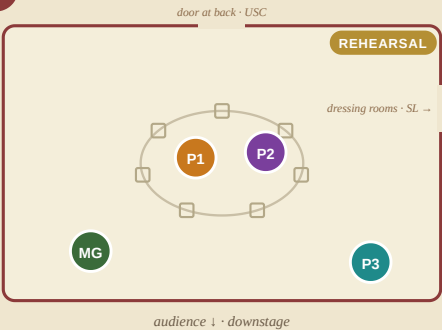
[The Actors and Actresses of the company enter from the back of the stage: first one, then another, then two together; nine or ten in all. Some move off towards their dressing rooms. The Prompter, the “book” under his arm, waits for the Manager].

2



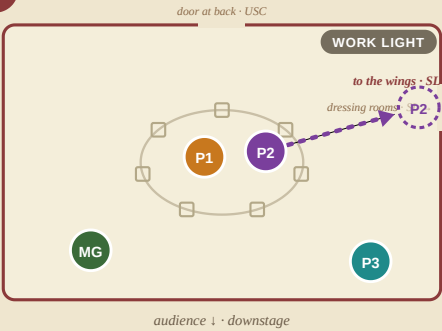
[Finally, the Manager enters with the precise weariness of a man who has managed the Village Players too long; he goes to his table, the Prompter turns on a light and opens the “book”].

3



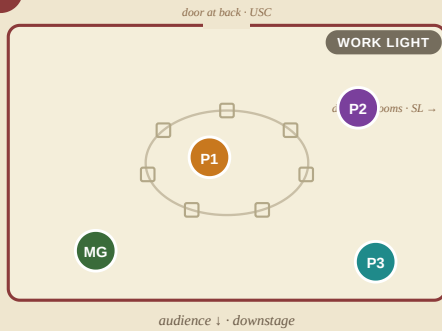
THE MANAGER *[to the Property Man].* A little light, please — if the house has any left to spare us this evening. **PLAYER 2** *[as Property Man].* Yes, sir. At once. *[A light comes down on to the stage].*

4



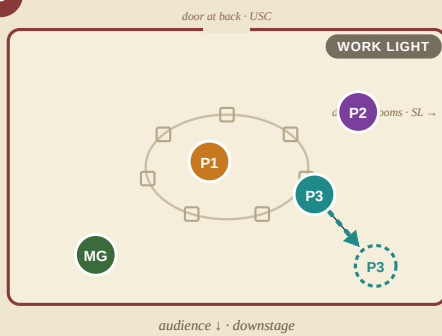
THE MANAGER *[clapping his hands].* Come along! Second act of “Mixing It Up” — and try, this time, to play it as if you wanted the public to come back for the third. *[The Actors go to the wings, all except the three who begin the rehearsal].*

5



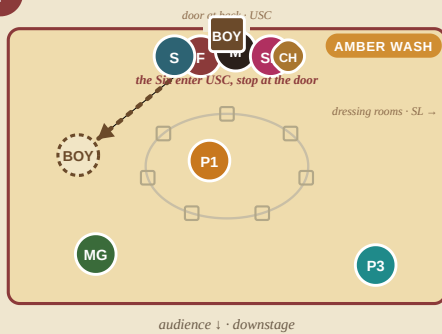
PLAYER 1 *[as Leading Man]*. Excuse me, but must I absolutely wear a cook's cap? It's ridiculous. I have a reputation in this canton — fifteen years. **PLAYER 2** *[as Property Man, not looking up]*. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

6



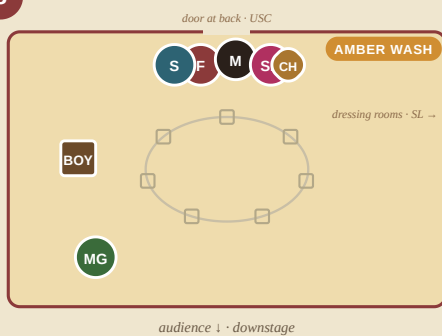
PLAYER 3 *[as Prompter, getting into the box]*. Pardon, sir — may I get into my box? There's a draught off that door, and I'd rather not be hoarse for my first proper season.

7



[The white working lights soften to a warm amber. The Door-keeper carries on the Boy-chair and sets it at the edge of the stage; the four live Characters — Father, Mother, Step-Daughter, Son — enter and stop by the door at back, the Step-Daughter carrying the Child-bundle].

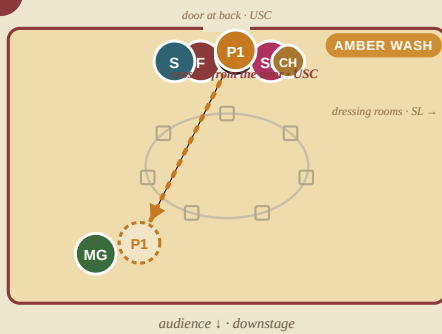
8



[A tenuous light surrounds the Six, almost as if irradiated by them — the faint breath of their fantastic reality. It will disappear when they come forward].

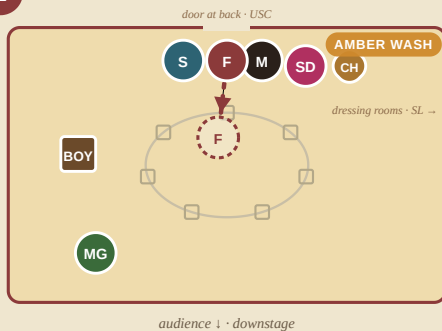
PART II — THE INTERRUPTION

1



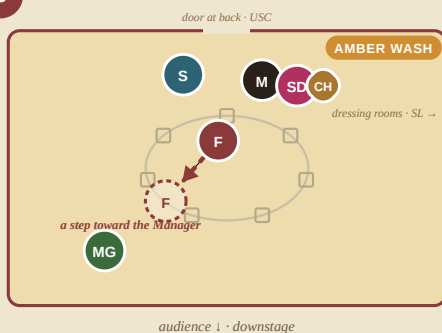
PLAYER 1 [*as Door-keeper, cap in hand*]. Excuse me, sir — these people are asking for you. I told them you were busy; they insist on coming in. **THE MANAGER** [*rudely*]. I am rehearsing — and you know perfectly well no one is allowed in during rehearsals!

2



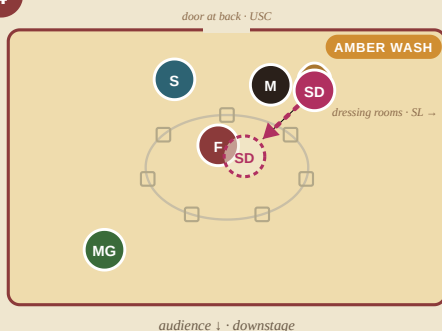
THE FATHER [*coming forward, the others following, embarrassed*]. No, for Heaven's sake, what are you saying? We bring you a drama, sir.

3



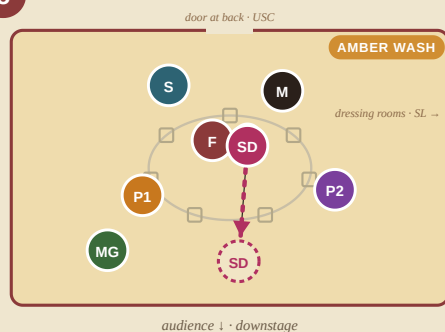
THE MANAGER. But what do you want here, all of you? **THE FATHER**. We want to live. **THE MANAGER**. For Eternity? **THE FATHER**. No, sir, only for a moment... in you.

4



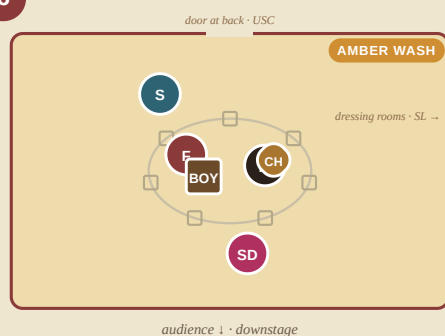
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*crossing behind the Father; a hand on his shoulder, left one beat too long, then withdrawn*]. My passion, sir. Ah, if you only knew — my passion for *him*.

5



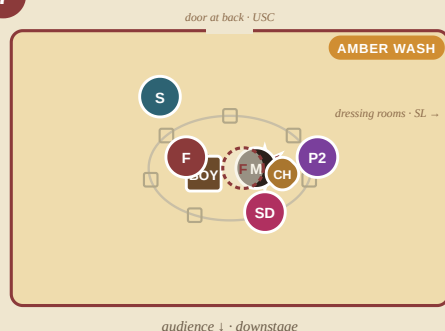
THE STEP-DAUGHTER. I, who am a two months' orphan, will show you how well I can dance and sing. *[Sings and dances Prenez garde à Tchou-Tchin-Tchou].*

6



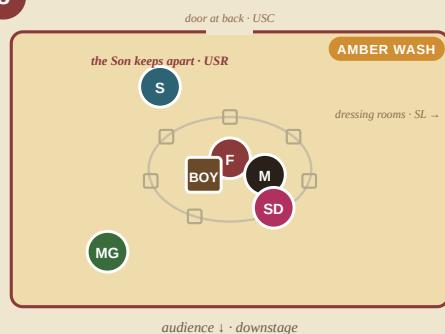
THE MOTHER *[one arm tightening round the Child-bundle, the other reaching for the Boy-chair, as if to hold both upright].* In the name of these two little children, I beg you... *[she grows faint]* Oh God!

7



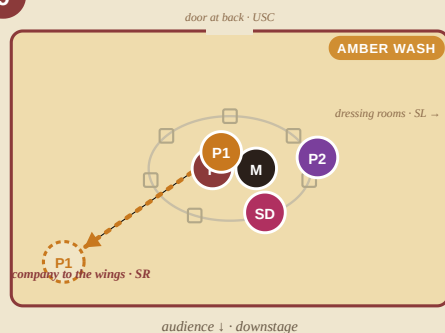
THE FATHER *[raising her veil].* Let them see you!

8



THE SON *[hands in his pockets, body not moving].* Leave me alone. I don't come into this. **THE FATHER.** What? You don't come into this?

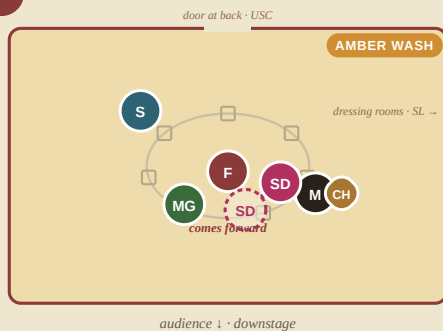
9



PLAYER 1 *[as Leading Man, beginning to relish it — then his eyes reach the Mother, and the rest does not arrive].* What a spectacle. What an absolute...

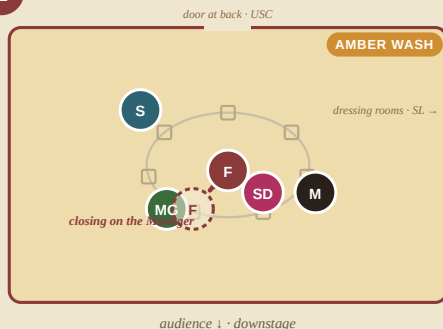
PART III — THE BARGAIN

1



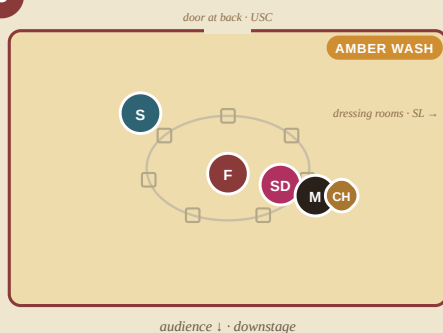
THE MANAGER. I begin to think there's the stuff for a drama in all this. **THE STEP-DAUGHTER** *[coming forward]*. When you've got a character like me. **THE FATHER** *[shutting her up]*. You be quiet!

2



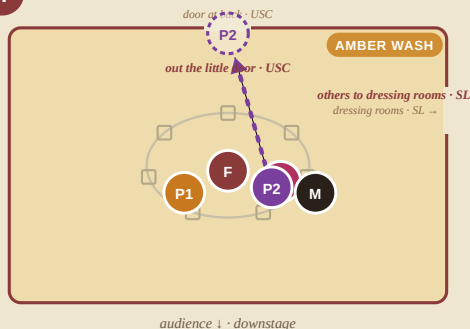
THE FATHER *[to the Manager]*. No, no — look here. You must be the author. **THE MANAGER.** I? Because I have never been an author: that's why. **THE FATHER.** Then why not turn author now?

3



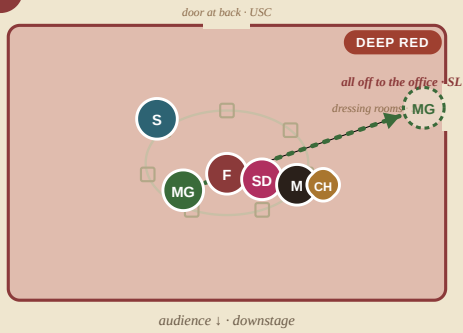
THE STEP-DAUGHTER. The room — I see it. The window with the mantles, the divan, the looking-glass, a screen, and the little mahogany table with the blue envelope and its hundred francs.

4



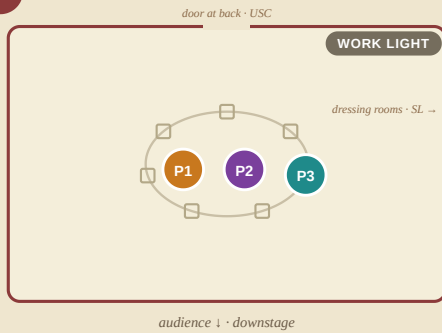
[Thus talking, the Actors leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back, others retiring to their dressing-rooms].

5



THE MANAGER [*hooked; leading the Father and the Six off to his office*]. Come with me to my office. In a quarter of an hour, all back here again. [*The Manager and the Six cross the stage and go off*].

6



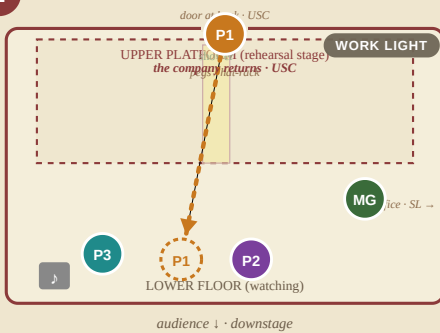
PLAYER 1 [*as Leading Man*]. Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

PLAYER 2 [*as Leading Lady*]. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed. **PLAYER 3**. Perhaps there is a play.

Act Two — The Theatre

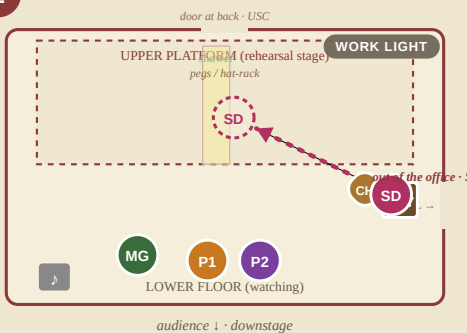
PART I — THE SETUP

1



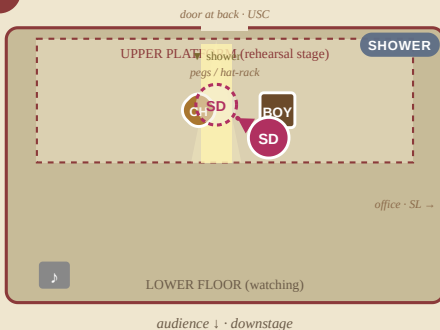
[The stage call-bells ring. From the dressing-rooms and the little door at the back the Actors, Stage Manager, Property Man and Prompter return; the Manager comes out of his office with the Father and the Step-Daughter].

2



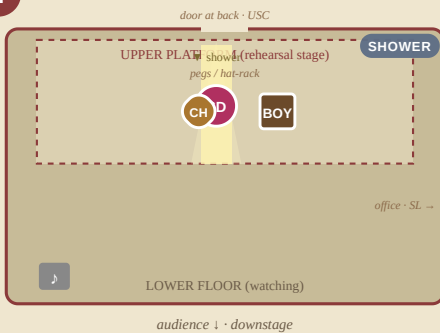
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*comes out of the Manager's office carrying the Child-bundle and dragging the Boy-chair, and cries*]: Come on, Rosetta, let's run!

3



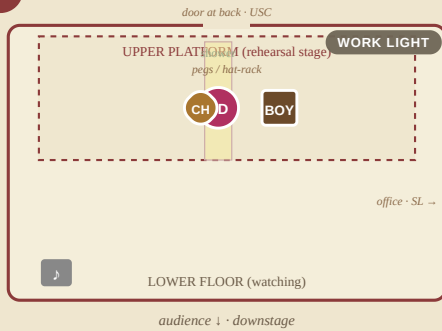
[She drags the Boy-chair a little behind her and leaves it leaning. The stage darkens; the shower — a tight vertical column of light from a single overhead source — falls on the Step-Daughter only. The pianist begins Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, and she kneels with the Child-bundle].

4



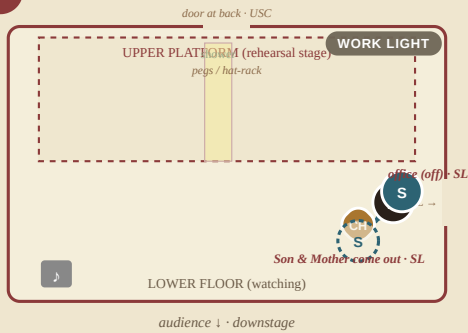
[She slides her hand into the coat pocket and finds the revolver. She holds it up briefly in the column of light, then returns it to the pocket].

5



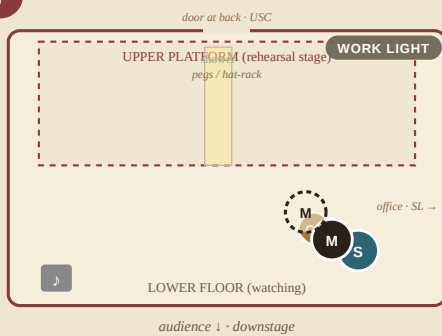
[The piano dies on her last word. The shower holds for one more breath, then releases. The working lights come up. The Step-Daughter is alone on the upper platform with the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair].

6



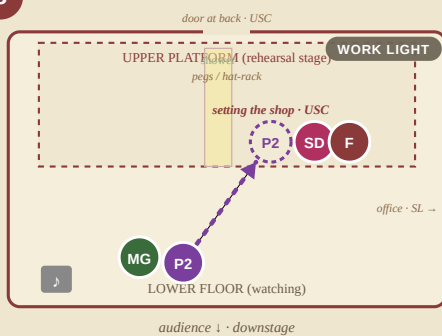
[The Father, Manager and Step-Daughter go back into the office (off); at the same time the Son, followed by the Mother, comes out].

7



THE MOTHER *[rises; one step toward the Son]. My son — [the Son turns away before the word is finished; she stops, and the unfinished word stays in the air].*

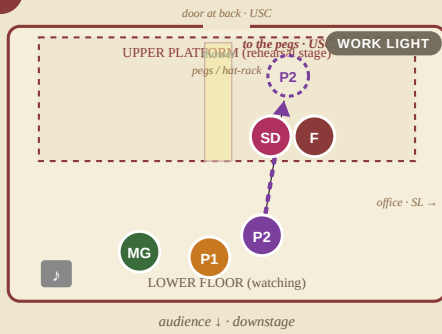
8



THE STEP-DAUGHTER. And the screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to manage? **PLAYER 2** *[as Property Man]. That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.*

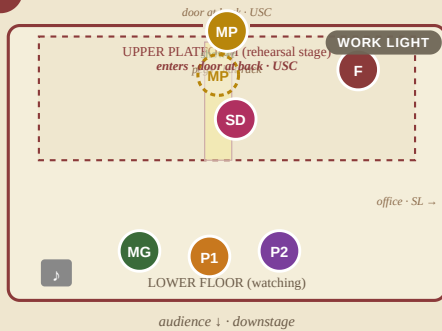
PART II — THE APPARITION

1



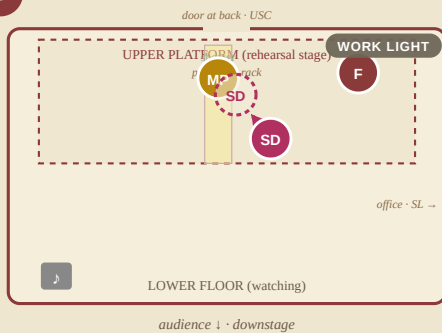
THE FATHER. Would the ladies mind hanging their hats and mantles on the pegs at the back? *[the actresses climb to the platform; the shop window and the screen are set].*

2



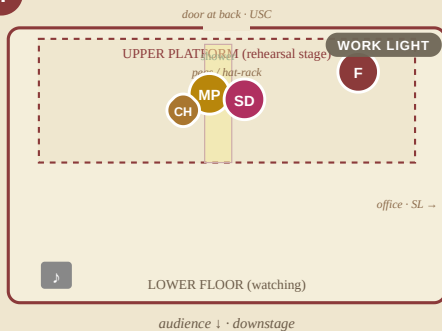
[The door at the back of stage opens and Madame Pace enters and takes a few steps forward — fat, bleach-blonde, the silver chain at her waist].

3



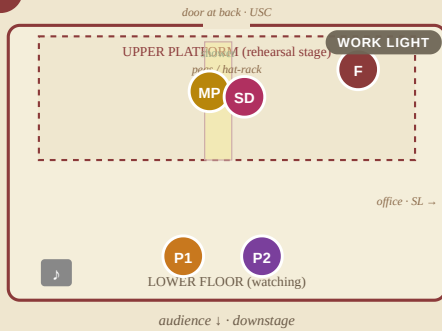
THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[running over to her]*. There she is! There she is!

4



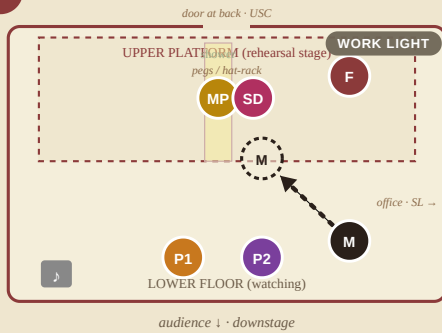
[Madame Pace places one hand under the Step-Daughter's chin to raise her head]. **MADAME PACE.** Good morning, good morning, sir! Madame Pace, sir — dresses and coats, off the rue de Bourg.

5



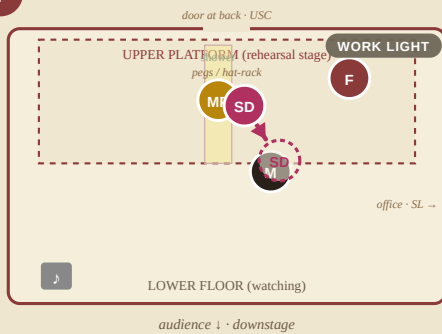
MADAME PACE [*the comedy curdling*]. Not so old, my dear. Not so old. Forty-five, maybe fifty — the age when a man have money in the pocket and shame in the throat, eh, sir?

6



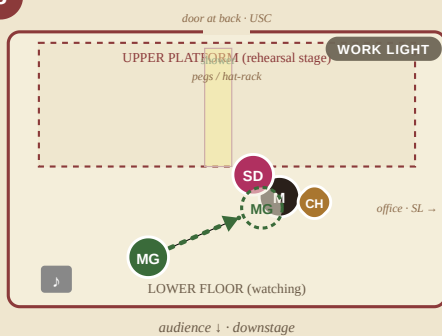
THE MOTHER [*jumping up amid the consternation of the actors — the voice she has not used for years*]. You old devil! You murderess!

7



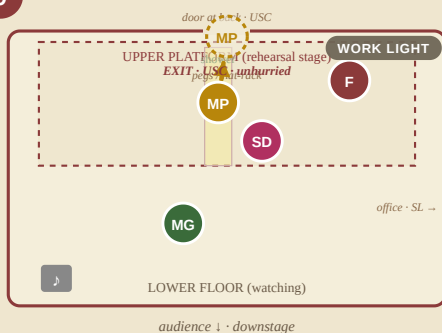
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*running over to calm her Mother*]. Calm yourself, Mother, calm yourself! Please don't...

8



THE MANAGER [*leading her to her chair*]. Come along, my dear lady, sit down now, and let's get on with the scene.

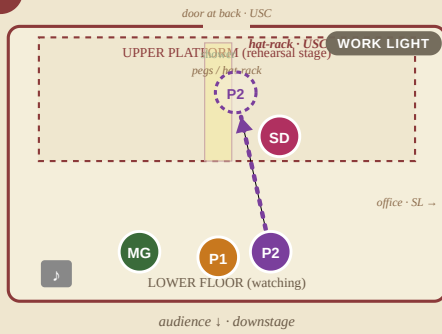
9



MADAME PACE [*pausing at the door, the smile calm now, almost tender*]. There is always the next silk, my dear. There is always the debt. There is always Pace. Don't you forget the name. [*Exits. Not furious. Unhurried*].

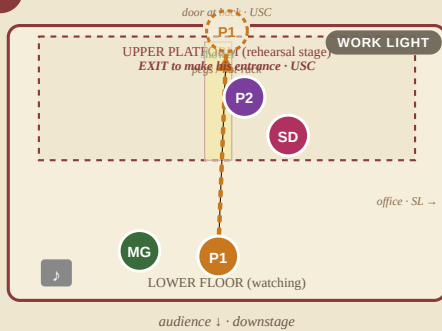
PART III — THE SUBSTITUTION

1



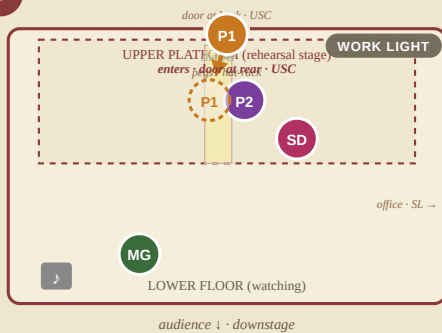
PLAYER 2 [as Leading Lady; goes to the hat-rack, puts her hat on, and takes the platform to play the Step-Daughter]. One minute. I want to put my hat on again.

2



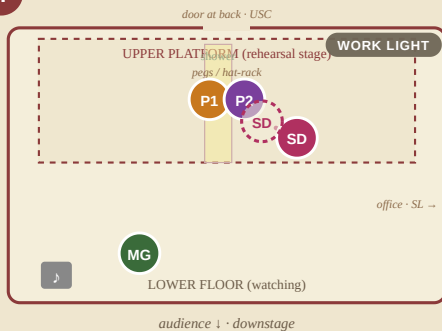
PLAYER 1 [as Leading Man]. Why, yes! I'll prepare my entrance. [Exit to make his entrance].

3



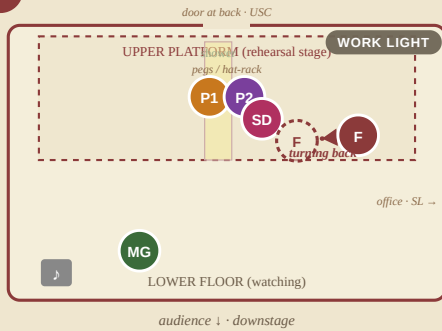
[The door at rear opens and the Leading Man enters with the lively manner of an old gallant]. **PLAYER 1** [as Leading Man]. Good afternoon, Miss.

4



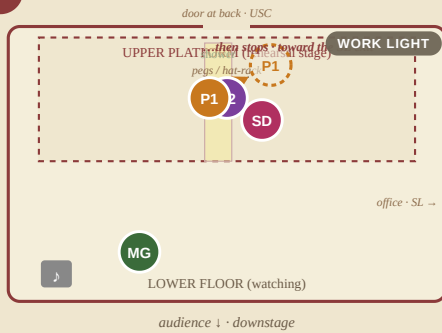
THE STEP-DAUGHTER [bursting out laughing, then advancing toward the actors]. He didn't say "I'm frightfully sorry." He said "Oh."

5



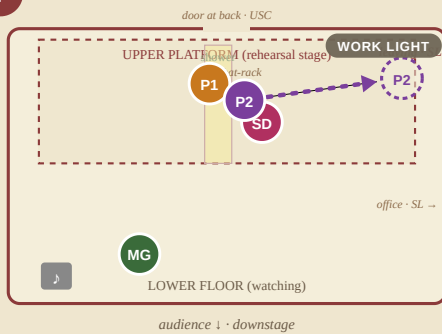
THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[low]*. And then he didn't move. His hand stayed on the hat. **THE FATHER** *[turning back, quietly]*. Yes. He said “Oh.”

6



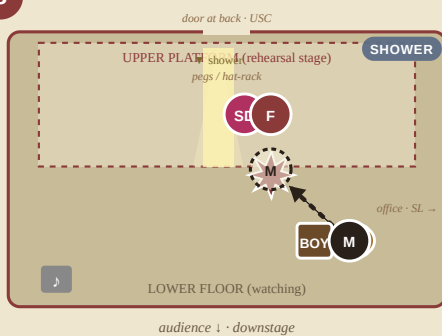
PLAYER 1 *[as Leading Man; two steps toward the exit — then a calculation crosses his face; he stops]*. Neither am I. I am through with this scene.

7



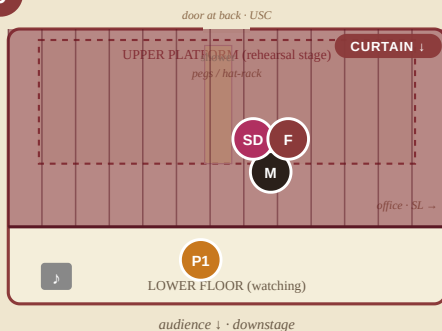
PLAYER 2 *[the diva's posture going from offended to leaving]*. I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman.

8



THE STEP-DAUGHTER. Cry out, mother. *Cry out as you did then!*
THE MOTHER *[coming forward to separate them; the shower falls on her]*. No! My daughter, my daughter! You brute!

9

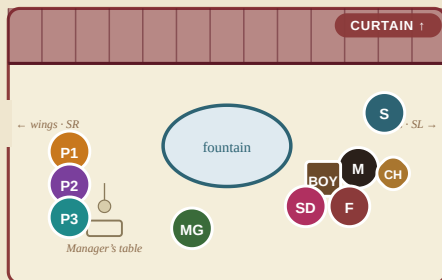


THE MOTHER. It's taking place now. It happens all the time. *[the piano cuts out; the Machinist drops the curtain by accident — the act ends on the curtain's fall]*.

Act Three — The Question

PART I — THE TRAP

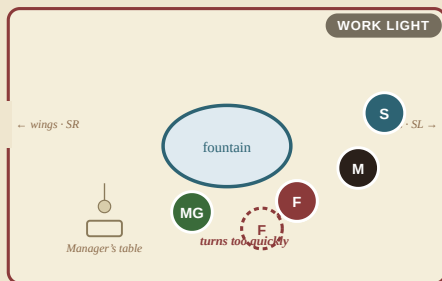
1



audience ↓ · downstage

[Curtain up. The two-level set is struck; the stage is bare but for a single fountain basin, centre. The family sit stage-right, the company stage-left; the Manager stands centre, hand over his mouth]. **THE MANAGER**. Ah yes: the second act!

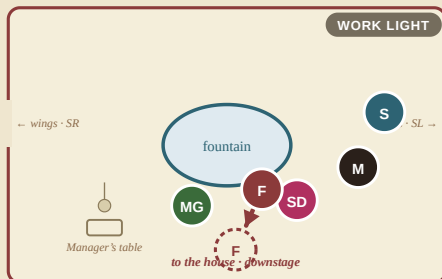
2



audience ↓ · downstage

PLAYER 2 [as Leading Lady]. The audience needs to know which room we are in. **THE FATHER** [the word lands physically — he turns too quickly]. The illusion — for Heaven's sake, don't say illusion. Don't use that word.

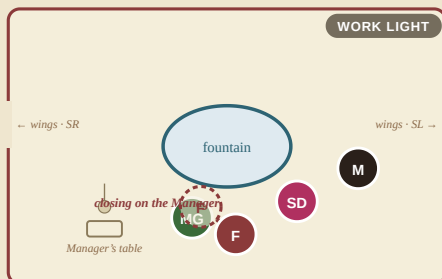
3



audience ↓ · downstage

THE FATHER [turning out toward the house; a pause long enough to feel]. Can you tell me who you are?

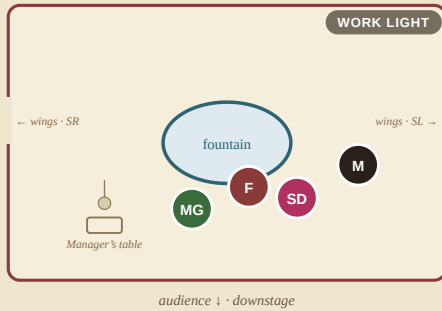
4



audience ↓ · downstage

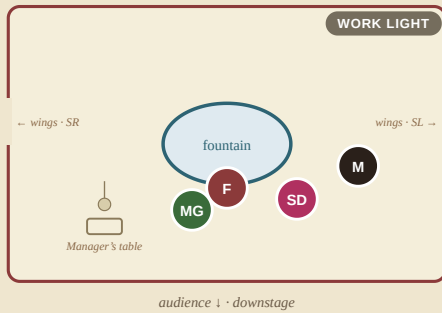
THE MANAGER. A man who calls himself a character comes and asks me who I am! **THE FATHER** [with dignity, not offended]. A character, sir, may always ask a man who he is. Because a character really does have a life of his own.

5



THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*level, never raised — colder than the philosophy*]. His reality. He always knew exactly where to find me.

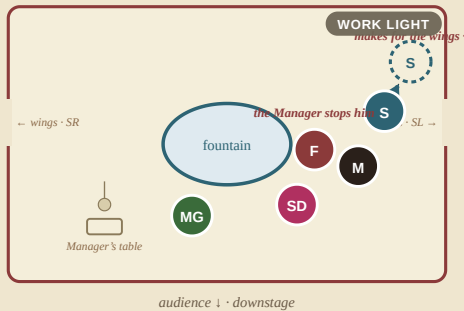
6



THE MANAGER. Then you'll be saying next that you are more true and real than I am? **THE FATHER** [*the greatest seriousness — no smile*]. But of course. Without doubt. **THE STEP-DAUGHTER** [*flat*]. He was real that afternoon. With his hundred francs.

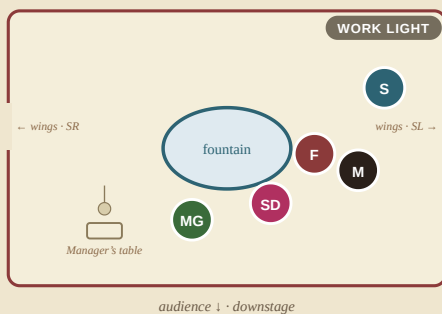
PART II — THE REFUSAL

1



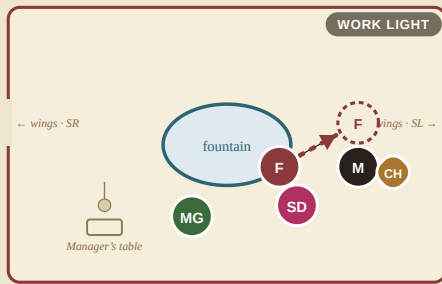
THE SON [*jumping up*]. Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. [*begins to move away*] **THE MANAGER** [*at once stopping him*]. No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

2



THE STEP-DAUGHTER [*calmly — she knows him*]. Don't bother to stop him. He won't go. **THE SON** [*trapped now, and knowing it*]. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat — I act nothing.

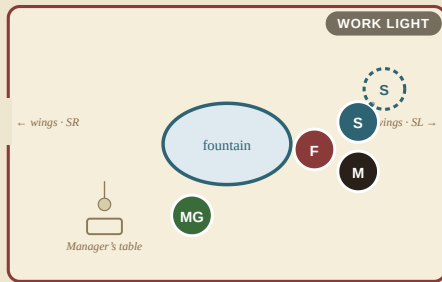
3



audience ↓ · downstage

THE FATHER *[seizing the Son, not leaving hold]*. You've got to obey, do you hear?

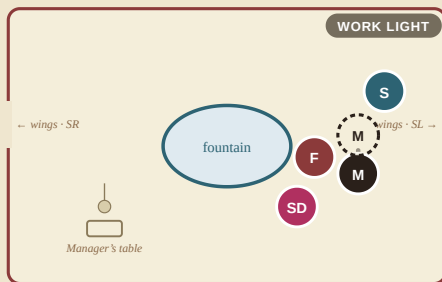
4



audience ↓ · downstage

THE SON *[the voice cracking, the body refusing the cry; they separate]*. What does it mean — this madness you've got? I won't do it. I won't.

5

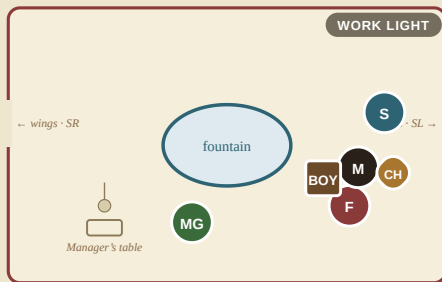


audience ↓ · downstage

THE MOTHER *[gets up, alarmed and terrified that he is really about to go, and instinctively lifts her arms]*. *[She does not reach him]*.

PART III — THE FOUNTAIN

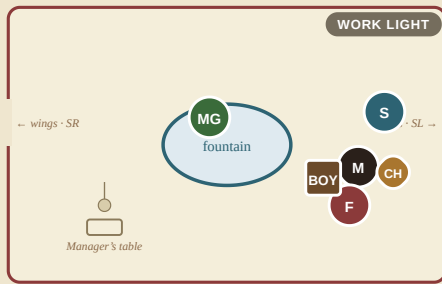
1



audience ↓ · downstage

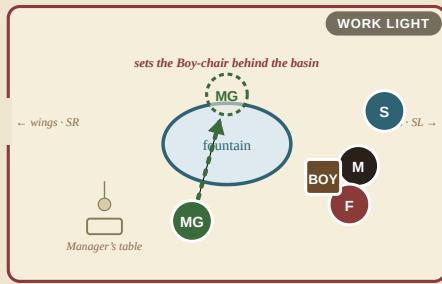
THE SON *[the cry he has been holding for the whole production — surprising himself]*. Yes — but haven't you yet perceived that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror that throws our likeness back at us with a horrible grimace?

2



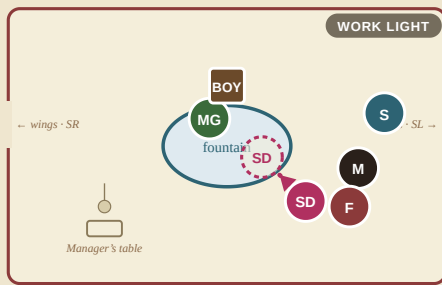
THE MOTHER. Yes. Into his room. I couldn't bear it any more. I went to tell him what I have inside me — all of it. *[a hand at her chest]* But the moment he saw me come in...

3



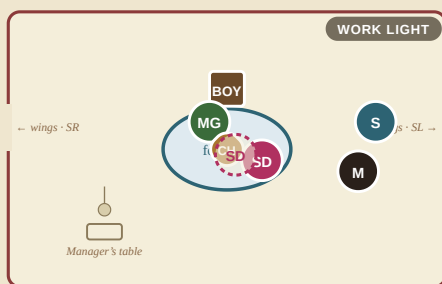
THE MANAGER *[he stands; he picks up the Boy-chair himself and walks it across the stage, and places it behind the fountain basin].*

4



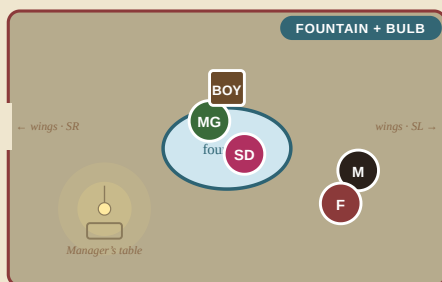
THE STEP-DAUGHTER *[lifts the Child-bundle from the Mother's lap and carries it toward the fountain].*

5



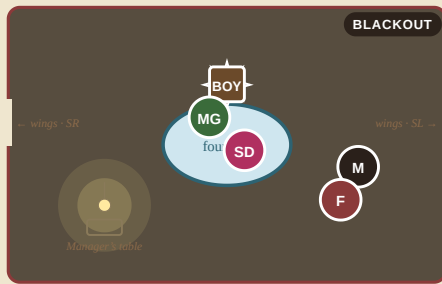
[The Step-Daughter bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it; the basin's walls hide the action from view].

6



THE SON *[his one continuous sentence; the stage lights drop, breath by breath, until only the fountain and the bare bulb over the Manager's table remain — the Boy-chair silhouetted behind the basin].* There in the fountain...

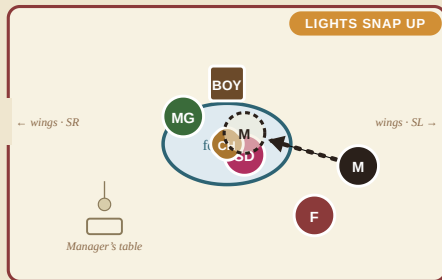
7



audience ↓ · downstage

[Full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the Boy-chair is].

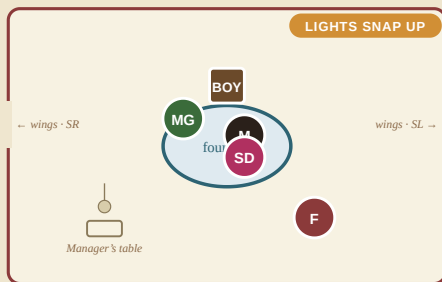
8



audience ↓ · downstage

THE MOTHER [she does not cry out at once — she reaches first for the Child-bundle in the basin, then the Boy-chair behind it; her arms cannot hold both, the veil still down]. My son! My son!

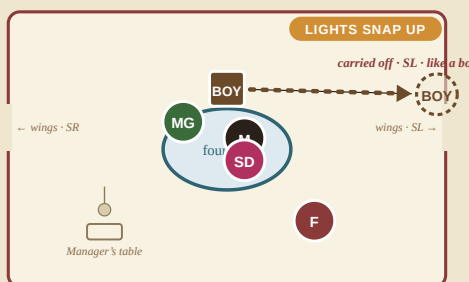
9



audience ↓ · downstage

TWO PLAYERS. He's dead! dead! **THE OTHER PLAYERS.** No, no — it's only make-believe, only pretence! **THE FATHER** [with a terrible cry]. Pretence? Reality, sir — reality!

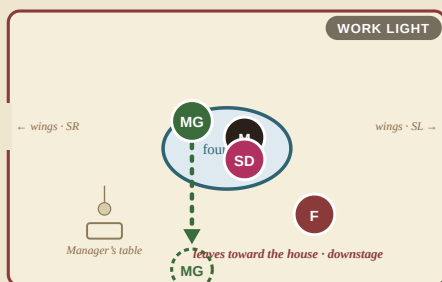
10



audience ↓ · downstage

[The Players lift up the Boy-chair and carry it off, handling it as if it were the Boy's body — heavy, careful, terrible].

11



audience ↓ · downstage

THE MANAGER [a look at the empty Boy-chair, then he turns and leaves the stage the way a man leaves a theatre]. Pretence? Reality? ... To hell with it all.